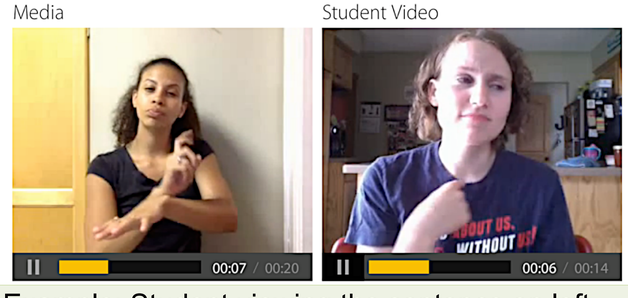
American Sign Language: Monitoring Student Progress

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Background

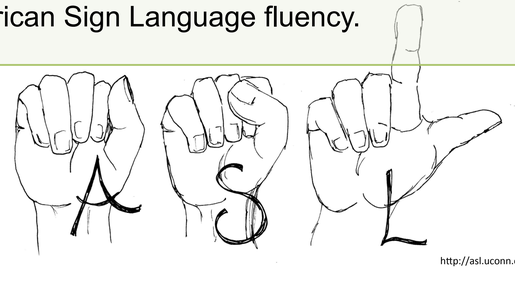
- Increasing number of students are taking **American Sign Language** (ASL) to fulfill world/ foreign language requirements in high school and post secondary settings.
- ASL is a visual language which poses unique challenges in teaching and learning.
- Teacher monitoring of student progress and provision of adequate feedback for improvement is notable since there is no written form for ASL.
- The researchers focus on identifying the feasibility of **Curriculum Based Measure** (CBM) in monitoring student ASL progress.
- CBM assessment measures the participant's ability to identify pictures and copy ASL sentences as indicators of language fluency.



Example: Student viewing the sentence on left and repeating the sentence on right.

Hypothesis

Picture naming and sentence retell are valid and reliable indicators of student progress in American Sign Language fluency.



Methodology

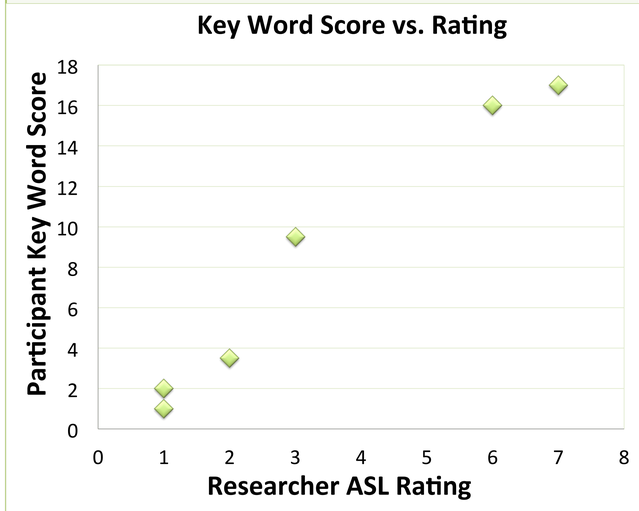
- 7 participants were recruited from a Deaf Education graduate program and the TRIO McNair Scholars Program.
- Participants were asked to rate their ASL skills on a 7 point scale and identify the number of ASL classes completed.
- Participants logged into AVENUE ASL software and completed 13 prerecorded tasks independently.
- Tasks prepared by the researcher included 5 photographs of common object (e.g. chair, dog) and 8 ASL based short sentences consisting of 4-9 ASL signs, ranging from easy to difficult.
- Participants' responses were automatically recorded and forwarded to the researcher.
- One external reviewer and I viewed participant responses and scored them independently.
- Scoring parameters included **key words**, **non-manual markers** (NMM), and accurate **completion of the sentence**.
- Key words were scored on a scale from 0-17, non- manual markers on a scale from 0-13, completion of sentence as yes or no, and picture naming as correct or incorrect.

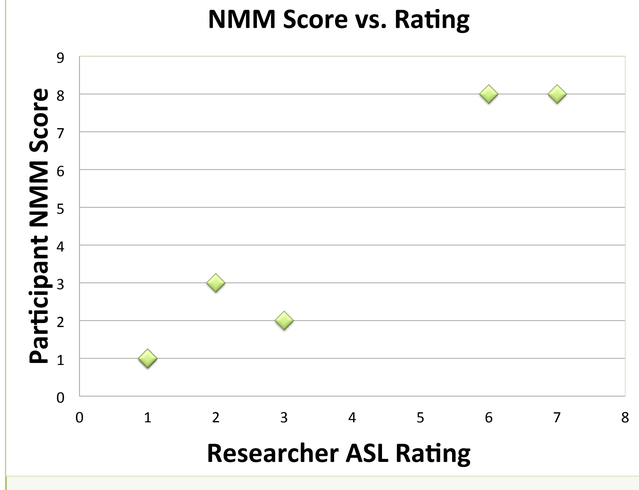
Discussion

- Sentence retell using key word scoring protocols appears to be a successful measure of ASL fluency.
- This CBM holds promise of reducing subjectivity in assessment, increasing the standardization of measures, and increasing the frequency of instructor feedback.
- Non-manual markers as a scoring parameter is not an effective measure of student progress.
- Scoring of NMM required a lot of discussion between scorers resulting in excessive time and increased opportunities for subjective scoring.
- Participants who were beginners in learning ASL were unable to recognize and copy NMM.
- Picture naming served as a preliminary measure of ASL vocabulary knowledge and not language fluency.

Results

Inter-rater reliability of scorers on the picture naming and sentence completion tasks was 100%, on key word scoring 95%, and 85% agreement on non-manual markers.





Acknowledgements

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